UNIVERSITY OF ST. LA SALLE

Graduate School
Bacolod City

ELECTRONIC APPROVAL AND SIGNATURE POLICY

Electronic approval and signatures | Operations Manual 4.22 | Proposed policy - for validation by the Graduate School

Form code	GS-P-03	Revision no.	00	Effectivity date	

INSTRUCTIONS

1. This policy proposes when an approval recorded in the Graduate School platform counts as the signature of the same officer on the matching GS-F form. It is a proposal for validation: it takes effect only when the Dean signs below. Every rule is marked proposed until then.
2. Until it takes effect, forms are signed on paper or, for the Research Protocol forms, with the e-signature sent by email as the Protocol already requires.
3. The laws are cited so that the Dean and the University's legal counsel can check them. This document is not legal advice.

1. Purpose and scope

1.1 Purpose: to let one act (the approval in the platform) stand for the officer's signature on the paper form, so that the platform and the paper file never disagree and nobody signs twice.

1.2 Covered: the endorsements, recommendations, approvals and decisions that the platform records for the holders of the roles Graduate School Staff, Academic Coordinator, Research Coordinator, Dean and Faculty Member (GS-P-05).

1.3 Not covered: signatures of people without a platform role - the Associate Dean, the Graduate School Secretary, the Business Office, the University Registrar, the Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs, host organizations (GS-F-11), editors and the Turnitin administrator. Their signatures stay on paper or by email until each accepts this policy in writing (proposed).

1.4 Not covered: a signature that is a legal undertaking by a student, such as the Practicum Agreement (GS-F-11) and the consent on GS-F-45. A request a student files while signed in to the student portal is the student's application for that request; whether it replaces the student's signature is an open point (section 7).

2. Legal basis

2.1 Republic Act No. 8792, the Electronic Commerce Act of 2000: section 7 gives electronic documents the legal recognition of written ones; section 8 makes an electronic signature equivalent to a handwritten signature when a procedure that the parties cannot alter identifies the signer, is reliable for the purpose, is needed for the signer to go on with the transaction, and can be verified by the other party; section 9 sets a presumption for electronic signatures; section 12 deals with the admissibility and weight of an electronic data message or document. Section titles checked against the text of the Act; the reading of section 8 is a paraphrase for counsel to confirm.

2.2 The Graduate School already works this way by email. The Research Protocol AY 2024-2025 and the Handbook (pp. 61, 63, 72-73) require Form 4 and Form 4.3 to be accomplished with e-signature and move Forms 3 and 3.1 by email between the Academic Coordinator, the Research Coordinator and the Dean (Operations Manual rules PRP-02, FIN-12, ADV-09). This policy applies the same idea to the platform.

3. The rule (proposed)

3.1 An approval, endorsement, recommendation or decision recorded in the platform by the signed-in holder of the role named on a GS-F form counts as that officer's signature on that form, at the date and time recorded.

3.2 The record is the transaction-log entry of the platform. It shows who acted (account holder and role), what was done and the result, when, the status before and after, the next owner and the source reference. The log entry, not a screenshot or a printout, is the evidence.

3.3 Only the holder of the account may act. An account is never shared and nobody approves in another person's name. A delegate (an authorized representative, where a form allows one) approves from the delegate's own account, with a written designation filed with the Dean.

3.4 The shared demonstration accounts used to present the platform carry no authority. An approval made with them is a demonstration, not a signature.

3.5 A paper copy is allowed: the Graduate School may print the form with the log entry attached. A correction is a new, later step with its reason; the earlier entry stays.

Role	Approvals the platform records for the role (checked in the role gates of the platform)	Forms
Dean	Acceptance of the onboarding report; approval of the term course offering plan; decisions on leave, readmission, withdrawal and absence-without-leave cases; approval of adviser appointments; approval of graduation endorsements and the endorsed list	GS-F-01, 04, 05, 07, 08, 09, 20, 42, 43, 48
Academic Coordinator	Review of study plans and subject status; course adjustment plan; Form 1 endorsement; noting of adviser applications; coursework check for graduation; practicum verification	GS-F-02, 03, 13, 16, 19, 42
Research Coordinator	Adviser appointment record; panel invitations; defense scheduling decisions; validation of research documents for graduation	GS-F-17, 19, 20, 21, 27, 28, 43
Graduate School Staff	Preparation and recording (batches, imports, registrar exports); the steps of a case that the staff own. Staff record; they do not approve in place of the Dean	GS-F-01, 43, 44
Faculty Member	Reply to a panel invitation; acceptance of an adviser appointment; defense verdicts for the member's own panels	GS-F-17, 18, 20, 29, 32, 33

4. How the platform meets the legal test

Requirement of RA 8792 section 8 (paraphrased)	What the platform does (verified in the code)	Gap or limit
The signer is identified	One account per person; the sign-in name is the institutional email; the role is stored on the account and a role sent by the browser is ignored	Accounts are created outside the platform for most roles (GS-P-05)
The method is reliable	Passwords are stored as hashes; a generated password must be replaced at first sign-in (at least 10 characters); repeated wrong passwords are slowed (a wait that doubles up to 30 seconds); signing out ends the session; the session cookie is HttpOnly and SameSite Lax, and Secure when the site runs over HTTPS	No second factor; the wait counter is kept in memory and resets on restart
The signature is needed to go on	A case moves forward only when the role named for the step records it; other roles are refused with a message	-
It cannot be altered and the other party can verify it	Each step appends a log entry with the actor, role, time and the statuses; no screen or route edits or deletes an entry	Entries are removed with the student record if that record is ever deleted; the platform's own clock is the only time source; no certificate or hash chain (to review before real use)

5. Limits and fallbacks (proposed)

5.1 Where this policy does not apply, or while the platform is unavailable, the form is signed on paper or by email as today and keyed in afterwards, with the note "signed on paper on [date]".

5.2 A person who disputes an approval asks the Dean to review the log entry. The Dean's decision is recorded as a new entry.

5.3 Retention of the log and the forms follows the retention schedule in GS-P-04, section 8.

6. Open points for the Graduate School

6.1 Does the University's legal counsel accept the procedure above as meeting RA 8792 section 8, or does the University require a certificate-based signature for some documents (for example the graduation list sent to the Registrar)?

6.2 The Associate Dean signs several forms but has no platform role (GS-P-05). Should the role be added, or does the Associate Dean keep signing on paper?

6.3 May a request a student files while signed in replace the student's signature on the matching form? How is a delegate designated and for how long?

Review and approval

Role and action	Printed name	Signature	Date
Prepared by Capstone group CAP-IT1 (platform project)			
Reviewed by Research Coordinator and University legal counsel (to be confirmed)			
Approved by Graduate School Dean			